

Chapter 146-1

Unusually, they didn't do anything that night.

Even though they kissed until they couldn't bear to part, it was limited to just passionate kissing.

All their emotions were contained within those kisses—tender and lingering.

Xu Qingzhu's crying stirred Liang Shi's compassion countless times. During the pauses between kisses, Liang Shi would say while breathing heavily: "Zhuzi, stop overthinking, okay?"

Faced with her crying, Liang Shi was quite at a loss.

She could only respond with kisses.

On the sofa in the living room, on the bed in the dimly lit room, on the bay window that carried a hint of cold.

Countless passionate kisses, countless times pulling apart.

They kissed until Liang Shi's tongue tasted of blood.

Xu Qingzhu nestled in her arms and said: "Jiejie, I really want to keep you trapped at home."

Even though she was already lost in desire, Liang Shi couldn't help but find it both amusing and touching. Still, she responded slowly and affectionately: "What would you do if you trapped me at home?"

"I want to see you every day." Xu Qingzhu stared at her, her fingertips brushing across her lips. "Make you mine alone. No one else can look at you."

Liang Shi teased her: "Didn't you tell me before to go film kissing scenes and bed scenes? Didn't you tell me that actors need to be professional? How could an actress only let you see her?"

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu's brow furrowed tightly. Not knowing what she was thinking of, she suddenly buried herself in Liang Shi's arms and cried, her voice muffled.

Liang Shi wanted to coax her, but before she could speak, Xu Qingzhu said while crying: "That's not what you're supposed to say."

Liang Shi was surprised: "Then what should I say?"

Xu Qingzhu's tears soaked through Liang Shi's thin inner clothing, all falling onto her skin.

After crying enough, Xu Qingzhu said in a hoarse voice: "You should say, although an actress can't only let me see her, for my sake, you're willing to only let me see you."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi was so amused by her that she laughed out loud. But then Xu Qingzhu froze for a moment, tears immediately falling again as she reached out to pat her shoulder: "You're not allowed to laugh."

Xu Qingzhu said very seriously: "I told you, even if you're lying to me, you have to lie to me properly."

"Whatever you want, I'll give it to you, okay?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Just tell me whatever you want, and I'll definitely cooperate unconditionally."

"Even if your mission is..." She paused. "To kill me."

Liang Shi was startled: "What are you talking about? If you keep saying things like this, I'm really going to get angry. How could I possibly hurt you? Xu Qingzhu, stop talking nonsense."

"Aw~" Xu Qingzhu's tone relaxed a bit. "Just like that."

Like a cat that had just woken up, Xu Qingzhu nuzzled her head back and forth in Liang Shi's arms, as if trying to please her owner: "I really like it when you're all serious like that~"

Her hoarse voice unconsciously softened, making one's heart flutter.

Liang Shi stroked the top of her head. Xu Qingzhu said in a muffled voice: "When you kiss me, you need to use more force. That's when I like it."

Liang Shi didn't understand what she meant by this request, but she did as she asked.

Xu Qingzhu had drunk a lot of alcohol, and when she kissed back, she was recklessly wild, her whole being restless.

A person who was usually calm and composed, once lost in love, became a complete fool.

So Liang Shi went along with her wildness.

When she was kissed until she could barely breathe, Xu Qingzhu whispered secretly in Liang Shi's ear: "Jiejie, I really like the way you kiss me."

"Like this..." Xu Qingzhu took her earlobe into her mouth, half her body draped over Liang Shi, her voice impossibly soft. "I feel like I'm being properly loved by you."

Chapter 146-2

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Early the next morning, sunlight streamed in through the gaps in the dark curtains. Downstairs, vehicles began to flow like shuttles, just like the water in the Yu River.

The entire city was like a wind-up gear mechanism—with just a light push, it began to turn.

Xu Qingzhu turned over and instinctively reached for the space beside her, only to find it cold.

Her head hurt so much it felt like it was about to explode.

A hangover was never pleasant, especially when she hadn't drunk any hangover soup the night before.

Having drunk so much alcohol and then standing in the cold wind on a winter night while dressed so thinly—the headache was doubled.

Xu Qingzhu raised her hand to press her temples. She was only wearing a camisole. Her slender, fair arms looked the same as usual, except for a ring of red marks on her wrist and bluish-purple bruises on her elbows.

She had rather sensitive and delicate skin—normally, the slightest touch would turn red.

And everything that happened last night had been forgotten by her.

The problem of blacking out when drunk wouldn't change just because she had done strange things while intoxicated.

In fact, whether beautiful or sad, everything would be forgotten cleanly once she woke up.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at the red marks on her wrist and the bluish-purple bruises on her elbow, unable to recall what had happened last night no matter how hard she tried.

The headache continued.

The room was dim, with no lingering romantic scent.

The space beside her was empty.

Xu Qingzhu wanted to call out for Liang Shi, but found that her voice was so hoarse she could barely make a sound.

Even speaking made her vocal cords ache, and her mouth hurt too.

Her entire tongue was numb. She tried to lick her lips with the tip of her tongue, only to find that she couldn't even manage this simple action.

It was a bit excessive.

But she was certain they hadn't done *that* last night.

So she was even more curious about what they had done.

She couldn't even remember who she had come home with.

Her memory only went up to going downstairs with her secretary to see off the business partners, and after that, she couldn't remember anything.

Xu Qingzhu wearily leaned against the headboard, pressing her temples, then rubbing her throat. There was a glass of warm water on the nightstand. She picked it up and took a few sips, finally feeling a bit better.

Her ears were sharp, and she could hear faint sounds coming from outside.

So she was certain Liang Shi was home, just not sure what she was doing.

There was the sound of running water, so she wasn't sure if Liang Shi was washing up or cooking in the kitchen.

Meanwhile, she was desperately trying to recall what had happened last night.

The more she tried to remember, the less she could recall.

Eventually, she stopped tormenting herself and put everything out of her mind.

The main thing was the red marks on her wrist—they looked like something had been tied around them.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu discovered a black tie next to her pillow. It was one that matched a shirt of hers, the kind that was half-tied and could be pulled on easily.

The reason she remembered so clearly was because she had bought this shirt near graduation, thinking she would wear it to work.

But she never ended up going to work, though the shirt was still kept.

It had been sitting unused in the closet for a long time.

Yet this tie had suddenly been taken out, and there were signs it had been used—it looked all wrinkled.

Xu Qingzhu frowned as some not-so-innocent scenarios began to appear in her mind.

They were all from her own imagination, but the more she thought about it, the more she blushed.

She thought that if they had really done *that*, she might have to flee the planet today.

Xu Qingzhu felt her ears burning. She pinched her earlobes, staring at the black tie again and again, before finally tossing it aside and getting out of bed as if escaping.

But she didn't expect her legs to go weak the moment she stood up. She was wearing silk shorts.

At the instant she tried to stand, her knees ached faintly.

Xu Qingzhu sat back down on the edge of the bed. Looking down, she discovered that her knees were also bruised.

Elbows, knees... bruises.

It was really hard not to overthink.

But no matter how much she thought about it, it was all about bedroom activities. Yet Xu Qingzhu didn't think any bedroom exercise could injure her like this.

She lowered her gaze and tried to remember again, but still couldn't.

She had no choice but to give up.

She rubbed her knees, but those bruises weren't going to fade anytime soon.

Seeing all this first thing in the morning put Xu Qingzhu in a rather bad mood.

What made her most uneasy was not being able to remember how she got these marks.

Just as she was feeling distressed, the bedroom door was gently pushed open. Without even turning her head, she knew it was Liang Shi. She just kept her head down, rubbing her knees.

Seeing that she was awake, Liang Shi no longer tiptoed around. She entered the room and walked over to her: "You're awake?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu continued rubbing her knees without looking up.

Liang Shi went to pull open the curtains, then bent down and crouched to examine her injuries: "How did it get this serious?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned: "How do you have the nerve to ask?"

Liang Shi: "?"

"Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu questioned her: "Tell me the truth—did you abuse me after I got drunk?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"You really don't remember anything?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu didn't respond, just stared at her unblinkingly.

Before Liang Shi could say anything, Xu Qingzhu suddenly reached out and poked near her mouth: "What happened to your mouth? Why is the corner of your lip split?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Chapter 146-3

This feeling of being the only one who remembered was quite uncomfortable.

Mainly because everything that happened last night was too embarrassing to talk about.

First, during a break from kissing, Xu Qingzhu had gone to the bathroom. When she came back, Liang Shi thought she was going to rest, but instead she excitedly rummaged through the closet and found a shirt.

She just tossed the shirt aside and kept only the tie, then put her hands together above her head.

Liang Shi was shocked at the time, thinking: Are we really going this far?

Xu Qingzhu said: "I heard this is... really fun."

Liang Shi: "....."

She even used that tie to blindfold herself later.

When the eyes can't see, all other senses become infinitely heightened.

But later, Liang Shi felt sorry for her wrists and set the tie aside, coaxing her to sleep.

But then Xu Qingzhu kept provoking Liang Shi, saying Liang Shi didn't have enough stamina.

As a result, she was kissed by Liang Shi until she nearly suffocated.

Yet she just smiled and said in a particularly soft voice: "So it turns out I'm the one who can't keep up."

Liang Shi pressed her head into her embrace and said huffily: "Good that you know. Now sleep."

But unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu said: "Then I need to work hard and exercise."

Then she flipped over and propped herself up on Liang Shi in a plank position.

Liang Shi was confused and asked what she was doing.

Xu Qingzhu said with a serious face: "Planking."

"Then why are you planking on top of me?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu pursed her lips, leaned down to kiss her, and said: "This way I have motivation."

So every time she couldn't hold it and was about to collapse, Liang Shi served as her cushion.

During those times when she really couldn't hold on but refused to admit defeat, she chose to put her legs on either side and kneel on the bed to do the plank.

It was purely self-deception.

Yet she was having the time of her life.

Liang Shi was helpless but could only play along with her.

Letting her enjoy herself to the fullest.

The crazier she had been last night, the more relieved she should be that she forgot today.

And after hesitating, Liang Shi decided to just let her forget.

"How would I dare abuse you?" Liang Shi said. "Baby, promise me you won't get drunk anymore, okay?"

Xu Qingzhu puffed out her cheeks, paused for a moment, then said: "I want to hear it again."

She said it without much confidence.

When sober, even making such a request came out mumbled.

Liang Shi didn't hear clearly: "Say what?"

"What did you just say?" Xu Qingzhu asked back.

Liang Shi said: "I told you not to get drunk."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "What about before that? The term of endearment."

Liang Shi hesitated. Thinking of her obsession from last night, her heart softened in an instant: "Baby."

"Ai."¹ Xu Qingzhu beamed with joy, no longer dwelling on the bruises on her body. She raised her arms, still carrying a bit of drowsy coquettishness: "Teacher Liang, come give your baby a hug."

The cold winter sunlight streamed in, making all the beauty seem as vibrant as late winter coming to life.

After Xu Qingzhu finished speaking, her palms were covered in cold sweat.

It was the first time she had said something like this, and the first time she had been so bold.

She was afraid of being rejected.

Fortunately, after hesitating, Liang Shi leaned in and hugged her tightly, her hand falling on the ends of her hair. Her voice was both helpless and indulgent: "Baby, what am I going to do with you?"

Xu Qingzhu directly wrapped her legs around her waist, her fingers tangling in her hair, trying to negotiate with her: "Spoil me, okay?"

Liang Shi braced one hand on the bed. Someone who exercised regularly had no trouble holding the slender Xu Qingzhu—she stood up easily, carrying her out of the room like carrying a child. She agreed readily: "Okay."

Footnotes:

¹ "Ai" (哎): A Chinese interjection used to acknowledge being called, similar to saying "yes" or "here" when someone calls your name. In this context, Xu Qingzhu is playfully responding to being called "baby."

Chapter 146-4

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That day when Xu Qingzhu went to work, she ran into Lin Luoxi again.

Lin Luoxi stared at her lips for quite a while, then said with some surprise: "They're a bit swollen."

Xu Qingzhu touched the corner of her mouth: "It's not that bad."

Lin Luoxi looked at her lovesick appearance and helplessly poked her forehead: "Little sister, honestly, your feelings are written all over your face. Tone it down a bit."

Xu Qingzhu immediately put on a cold expression, but when Liang Shi was mentioned, she couldn't help but break into a smile: "She seems to have suddenly figured things out."

"That's quite good." Lin Luoxi clicked her tongue. "A little couple reeking of love everywhere they go."

Xu Qingzhu shrugged: "What you said before, I think it all makes a lot of sense. I'll slowly put it into practice."

She really had taken it as a love bible.

Lin Luoxi didn't mind: "As long as you think it works."

After Xu Qingzhu left, Lin Luoxi watched her energetic retreating figure and said: "People in love are really so unpredictable."

"Who?" Sally suddenly popped over. "Who's in love?"

Lin Luoxi rolled her eyes at her: "Could it be you and me?"

Sally looked innocent: "Aren't we passionately in love?"

Lin Luoxi: "...Get lost."

She turned and walked away after saying that, but Sally followed alongside her, chattering non-stop: "We just celebrated our love anniversary yesterday. Why are you being so cold?"

Lin Luoxi thought about the dumbbells she had given her and felt anger rising: "Hurry up and get lost."

But Sally didn't understand the phrase "hurry up"¹ and continued: "Is it because you think my gift was too shabby?"

Lin Luoxi stopped and smiled: "I just feel like my body isn't healthy."

Sally panicked: "Babe, what's wrong? Where does it hurt?"

Lin Luoxi said unhurriedly, enunciating two words: "...My eyes."²

Sally: "?"

The two gradually walked further away. Xu Qingzhu, who had heard the whole thing, smiled and sent a message to Liang Shi: [Wifey, I just heard Xixi and Sally arguing.]

Liang Shi replied instantly: [Arguing about what?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Just bickering.]

Liang Shi: [Alright. Remember to drink more hot water today. I put honey packets in your bag.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Okay.]

After a while, Liang Shi sent her another message: [Baby, work hard.]

Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen and suddenly smiled.

A moment later, she replied: [Okay, baby.]

Footnotes:

¹ "Hurry up and get lost" (麻溜滚): "麻溜" (máliu) is a colloquial Northern Chinese expression meaning "quickly" or "hurry up." Sally, being a foreigner, didn't understand this slang term.

² "My eyes" (眼睛): Lin Luoxi is sarcastically saying she must be "blind" for being with Sally, implying she made a bad choice—a self-deprecating joke in response to Sally's question about her health.

Chapter 146-5

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Liang Shi didn't know what was so different about this term of endearment. In her view, they all carried the same amount of love.

Sometimes when she called out Xu Qingzhu's three-character name, she felt like there was honey on the tip of her tongue.

But for Xu Qingzhu, it seemed to make a huge difference.

So she could satisfy Xu Qingzhu.

But after last night, whenever she used this term of endearment, or even typed these few characters in a chat box, it felt sickeningly sweet.

Yet at the same time, she quite liked this sickeningly sweet feeling.

Soon, the day came for Liang Shi to join the crew of "Mo Journey"¹.

The day before joining the crew, Gu Yixue created a group chat with her and Sun Chengcheng, along with two supporting actresses from the production.

This was still an all-female film.

Gu Yixue was famous for filming women. The women in her lens each had their own kind of beauty—some were sensual, some were pure, some were glamorous, and some were cool and handsome.

Different people were filmed differently, and Gu Yixue could bring out all the beautiful qualities in a person to the fullest.

And she had mastered this even at a very young age.

During her days off, Liang Shi had done a lot of research on Gu Yixue.

She was exceptionally bold and very good at using newcomers.

The newcomers who had acted in her films gave outstanding performances, but their subsequent development inevitably fell into convention.

It wasn't that they weren't stunning in appearance or lacked acting skills—they simply didn't have the same spiritual quality they had shown in that film.

After looking into all this, Liang Shi became even more worried about collaborating with Gu Yixue.

However, since this was a rare opportunity, there naturally came with it a certain amount of risk.

Compared to the risk, Liang Shi felt this was more of an opportunity.

It was also her first time meeting a genius director like Gu Yixue.

After creating the group chat, Gu Yixue sent out a special announcement.

A particularly cool and aloof message, which matched Liang Shi's impression of her perfectly.

[Gu Yixue: @everyone, if anyone doesn't want to act, tell me now. I can replace people at any time. Nothing in the script is to be changed. I've already used the most appropriate words. You may be suitable for these roles, but understand that I'm the one who gives the characters their souls. Until you have sufficient ability, just do your own jobs well. If there are no objections, gather tomorrow at 3 PM at 79 Guanghua Road for a script reading session. Also, I hate people who aren't punctual.]

After seeing it, Liang Shi was the first to reply: [Received.]

The others also replied with "received" one after another.

Although Xu Qingzhu had said she wanted to wait until Liang Shi joined the crew before going on her business trip, she couldn't fight against work arrangements. She flew abroad on Tuesday and had already started adjusting to the time difference.

Leaving Liang Shi alone to guard an empty house.

When Liang Shi thought of this phrase, she surprised even herself, then smiled helplessly.

The room always felt so empty.

Xu Qingzhu wasn't there, yet it felt like Xu Qingzhu was everywhere.

She sat on the sofa and turned on the TV, which was playing a commercial featuring Yang Shuyan, showcasing Minghui Jewelry's new seasonal flagship piece.

Liang Shi casually put on a movie but couldn't muster any interest in its content—she used to be most focused when watching movies.

Halfway through, she got thirsty and stood up to go to the kitchen for water. The moment she got up, she instinctively asked: "Baby, do you want some water?"

After asking, she stood frozen in place.

After a long while, she sighed.

She seemed to instantly understand how Xu Qingzhu had felt before.

During the days when she wasn't around, Xu Qingzhu would often come back here, feeling like she should still be there.

But the house was clearly empty.

Liang Shi lost the desire to drink water. She sat woodenly on the sofa, picked up her phone intending to call Xu Qingzhu, but just then Xu Qingzhu's call came in. She immediately answered.

Before Xu Qingzhu could even speak, Liang Shi hugged a throw pillow and said somewhat pitifully: "Wifey, I miss you."

Xu Qingzhu, who had been feeling somewhat tired from jet lag, heard this and all the fatigue vanished from her face. Her eyes widened instantly, clearly filled with pleasant surprise.

Yet a moment later, she smiled and asked: "How much do you miss me?"

Liang Shi nodded: "So, so much."

Liang Shi told her what had just happened. Unexpectedly, after hearing it, Xu Qingzhu asked: "So what did you call me just now?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She raised an eyebrow: "Baby?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Not in that tone."

Liang Shi smiled helplessly, coaxing her like a child: "Baby, are you tired?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded at the camera: "Tired."

The secretary, who had already walked out but returned to remind President Xu about her business trip schedule, heard what Xu Qingzhu said and felt like her ears had gone deaf.

Th-th-this... was this President Xu?

The secretary swallowed and chose to quietly leave.

Footnotes:

¹ "Mo Journey" (心途, Xīn Tú): The title literally translates to "Heart's Journey" or "Journey of the Heart." The character 心 (xīn) means "heart" or "mind," and 途 (tú) means "journey" or "path."